

Seminar #10:
Your Own Local Church

Church comes from the Greek word *ecclesia*, meaning “called out” from darkness (1Corinthians 1:2). It refers to a local group of believers, a body of believers, the called out ones. It can also mean the church as universal.

I. WHAT IS LOCAL CHURCH ACCORDING TO THE NEW TESTAMENT?

The local church refers to...

- A. the fellowship or community of believers who recognize and express themselves as part of the whole Body of Christ.
- B. those who understand and believe the five ministries of Ephesians 4:11 as Christ’s gift to the worldwide church to bring the body of Christ to full maturity. (Ephesians 4:13)
- C. those under the leadership of the elders. (Hebrews 13:7)
- D. the believers, each of whom has a vital three-fold ministry:
 - a. to minister to the Lord. (1Peter 2:5)
 - b. to minister to others in the Body of Christ. (Romans 12:3-9)
 - c. to share the Gospel, to bring others to the Kingdom of God. (Matthew 28:19-20)
- E. the place where believers in fellowship, under the ministry of the Word of God and the anointing and guidance of the Holy Spirit, are brought to maturity in the image of Christ. (Ephesians 4:13)

II. WHY IS IT NECESSARY FOR EVERY BELIEVER TO BELONG TO A LOCAL CHURCH?

- A. It is God’s pattern. (Psalm 68:6; Hebrews 10:25)
- B. We need to be under authority. (Hebrews 13:17)
- C. We need to have a place where we can mature in the ministry God has called us through discipline and fellowship.

III. WHAT MUST A BELIEVER REMEMBER BEFORE JOINING A LOCAL CHURCH?

Every believer must keep in mind that joining or associating with a church does not save a soul (Romans 11:6; Acts 4:12). When he looks for the church where God will use him, that church should be a church that is founded and is burdened by God’s Word (1Peter 2:2; 1Corinthians 12:13-14).

Not only that... Such a church should be a place where the Holy Spirit moves and operates in freedom. And most importantly, souls must be its chief mission and priority.

IV. HOW DOES THE BELIEVER FUNCTION IN THE BODY OF CHRIST?

- A. He has an important role in the body of Christ. (Ephesians 4:16)
- B. He needs to find out what part God has for him in the local church.
- C. His role may be different from others. (Romans 12:4)
- D. He needs to accept the contribution of others and realize that without them, he is not complete. (Romans 12:5; Ephesians 4:25)
- E. He needs to submit completely to the Lordship of Christ and the authority Christ has placed over him in the local church. (Hebrews 13:17)
- F. He needs to commit himself willingly to all the other members of the local church.
- G. He needs to realize the importance of the love of God to enable himself to flow together in the part each one has to take. (Ephesians 4:16)

V. HOW SHOULD BELIEVERS RESPOND TO THE LOCAL CHURCH?

- A. Once you have chosen your local church after prayer and consultation with the Holy Spirit, then you should commit yourself fully.
- B. Support it.
- C. Love its pastors, workers and fellow brethren.
- D. Get involved in its mission to take the Gospel of Jesus Christ to the entire world.
- E. Let your commitment be first to God and then to the church.